

Could and was able to

Teaching guide

Distinguish past ability from a particular achievement.

Understand the distinction

Could commonly describes a general past ability: At ten, I could swim. For an actual achievement on one particular occasion, was/were able to or managed to is usually clearer: We were able to catch the last train.

The distinction is not absolute. Could is natural for particular past perceptions or mental states: I could hear music. Could not can describe a specific failure: I could not open the door. Could also expresses possibility and polite requests in other contexts.

Compare the patterns

GENERAL ABILITY

I could read when I was five.

A skill at a past age.

ACHIEVEMENT

We managed to finish before noon.

A successful result on an occasion.

PERCEPTION

I could hear the train coming.

A natural use for a particular past perception.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose for a skill you had as a child: When I was seven, I ___ swim.

A. will

B. can

C. could

2. Choose the phrase that reports an actual success: Yesterday, we ___ get the last two tickets.

A. tried to

B. hoped to

C. managed to

3. Is I could hear a bell outside natural?

A. Yes. Could commonly occurs with perception verbs.

B. No. Hear must always be in a continuous form.

C. No. Could can only describe general skills.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair reports a general childhood ability and then a specific successful result yesterday?

A. I could cycle when I was young. Yesterday I managed to repair a flat tire.

B. I will cycle when I was young. Yesterday I managed to repair a flat tire.

C. I could cycle when I was young. Yesterday I could have repaired a flat tire, but I did not.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. could

Could describes a general past ability. Was able to can also express past ability.

A: Will refers to the future here. At seven describes an ability in childhood, so use could.

B: Can describes present ability. This sentence describes a childhood skill in the past.

2. C. managed to

Managed to reports an actual successful result. Were able to can also express that meaning.

A: Tried to reports the attempt, not whether it succeeded. Managed to states the successful result.

B: Hoped to tells us what they wanted, but it does not say they succeeded in getting the tickets.

3. A. Yes. Could commonly occurs with perception verbs.

Do not apply the achievement rule to every past use.

B: Could hear is a normal way to describe a past perception.

C: Could is also natural with perception verbs such as hear.

4. A. I could cycle when I was young. Yesterday I managed to repair a flat tire.

Could describes the past skill; managed to reports the successful repair.

B: Will does not express the childhood ability in the past.

C: The second sentence explicitly says the repair was not done, so it is not a successful result.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-35.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair reports a general childhood ability and then a specific successful result yesterday?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.